

CRACK THE VOCABULARY CODE

Powerful Words, Verbs, Collocations & Expressions for CAIE English 1123

Choose precisely. Combine naturally. Write with impact.

Name: _____

Class: _____

Date: _____



SIR RUFUS TIP

A precise word is not simply a “difficult” word. It is the word that expresses the exact meaning and suits the situation naturally.

PRECISION WORD BANK

Study the meaning carefully. A stronger word is useful only when it matches the degree and context of the emotion.

Precise Word	Exact Meaning	Model Sentence
delighted	very pleased	I was delighted when my proposal was accepted.
devastated	extremely upset by a serious loss or failure	She was devastated when the final performance was cancelled.
petrified	extremely frightened	I stood petrified as footsteps approached the locked door.
apprehensive	worried about something that may happen	He felt apprehensive before addressing the large audience.
furious	extremely angry	The coach was furious when the team ignored the safety rules.
exhausted	extremely tired	After climbing for hours, we were completely exhausted.
astonished	very surprised	I was astonished by the sudden announcement.
bewildered	completely confused	The complicated instructions left the visitors bewildered.

POWER VERBS

Choose a verb that shows exactly how a person moved, spoke or looked. Do not replace “walked” or “said” randomly.

Verb	Meaning	Verb	Meaning
staggered	walked unsteadily	whispered	spoke very quietly
crept	moved slowly and secretly	muttered	spoke quietly and unclearly
strode	walked confidently with long steps	snapped	spoke suddenly and angrily
sprinted	ran at full speed	exclaimed	spoke with strong emotion
limped	walked with difficulty because of injury	glanced	looked quickly
trudged	walked slowly because of tiredness	stared	looked fixedly for a long time

ESSENTIAL COLLOCATIONS

A collocation is a natural combination of words. Learn the whole combination, not the individual words only.

Narrative	Directed Writing	Model Use
heavy rain	serious concern	Heavy rain created a serious concern for the organisers.
utter silence	practical solution	The hall fell into utter silence as the chairperson proposed a practical solution.
bitter disappointment	financial burden	The cancellation caused bitter disappointment, but the trip would have created a financial burden.
overwhelming relief	make a decision	With overwhelming relief, the committee finally made a decision.
fierce wind	lasting benefit	Despite the fierce wind, the project produced a lasting benefit for the community.

NATURAL EXPRESSIONS

Without warning • Before I could react • To my horror • Much to my relief • A wave of panic washed over me • I breathed a sigh of relief

COMMON MISTAKE

Do not write “strong rain”, “do a decision” or “hard disappointment”. Write heavy rain, make a decision and bitter disappointment.

EXERCISE 1 — MATCH THE PRECISE WORD

Write the correct letter beside each meaning.

WORDS	MEANINGS
A. delighted	1. ____ completely confused
B. devastated	2. ____ extremely tired
C. petrified	3. ____ very pleased
D. apprehensive	4. ____ extremely frightened
E. furious	5. ____ extremely angry
F. exhausted	6. ____ very surprised
G. astonished	7. ____ worried about a future event
H. bewildered	8. ____ extremely upset by a serious loss

EXERCISE 2 — CHOOSE THE BEST WORD IN CONTEXT

Circle the option that best matches the situation. More than one word may be grammatically possible, but only one is precise.

- After walking for six hours, the hikers were completely _____.
A delighted B exhausted C bewildered D furious
- Mariam felt _____ before opening the examination result.
A apprehensive B astonished C delighted D devastated
- The audience was _____ when the unknown singer received the highest score.
A furious B exhausted C astonished D petrified
- The injured player _____ towards the bench.
A sprinted B limped C strode D crept
- “Leave my room immediately!” Father _____.
A glanced B whispered C snapped D trudged
- The thief _____ across the dark corridor to avoid being heard.
A crept B strode C sprinted D staggered
- The manager expressed _____ about the rising cost of the project.
A heavy rain B serious concern C bitter wind D utter decision
- After hearing that everyone was safe, I _____.
A made a concern B breathed a sigh of relief C did a decision D felt heavy rain

QUICK CHECK

Ask two questions: Does the word express the exact degree? Does it create a natural sentence?

EXERCISE 3 — CORRECT THE UNNATURAL VOCABULARY

Each sentence contains an unsuitable word, verb, collocation or expression. Rewrite it naturally.

1. Strong rain began just as the match started.

2. The principal did a decision after speaking to the teachers.

3. The luxury hotel caused a hard disappointment for families who could not afford it.

4. The injured man sprinted slowly towards the ambulance.

5. She whispered loudly across the crowded hall.

6. I was delighted when my passport disappeared.

7. A wave of relief attacked me when I heard the good news.

8. The hall became an utter noisy place before the ceremony.

EXERCISE 4 — UPGRADE THE SENTENCE

Rewrite each sentence by using one precise word, one powerful verb or one natural collocation. Keep the original meaning.

1. The tired boy walked slowly towards the gate.

2. I was very scared when the lights went out.

3. The teacher looked quickly at the clock.

4. There was very heavy quietness in the room.

5. The committee was worried about the cost of the trip.

6. I felt very happy when the missing child was found.

SHOW, DON'T TELL — USE IT SELECTIVELY

At important emotional moments, show the physical signs of an emotion instead of merely naming it. Do not describe every ordinary action in excessive detail.

Emotion	Simple Telling	Controlled Showing
Fear	I was frightened.	My mouth went dry, and my hands began to tremble.
Anger	He was angry.	His jaw tightened as he struggled to control his voice.
Relief	I felt relieved.	I released the breath I had been holding and allowed my shoulders to relax.
Nervousness	She was nervous.	She twisted the edge of her sleeve and avoided everyone's gaze.

Exercise 5 — Rewrite the Emotional Moment

1. I was petrified when someone knocked on the window.

2. Sara was furious when she discovered the broken trophy.

3. I felt relieved when the doctor smiled.

4. Ahmed was apprehensive before giving the speech.

BAND 1 PARAGRAPH CHALLENGE

Rewrite the paragraph in 90–110 words. Use two precise words, two powerful verbs, one collocation and one natural expression. Underline the upgraded language.

WEAK PARAGRAPH

It was a bad morning. The weather was bad, and I walked to school. I was scared because I had to give a speech. When I went into the hall, everyone looked at me. I said my speech and felt happy when it finished.

CAIE NARRATIVE MINI-CHALLENGE

Write 120–150 words on the topic below. Use vocabulary from this worksheet only where it fits naturally. Underline five effective choices.

TOPIC

Write about a moment when you had to overcome fear and act bravely.

☐ precise word

☐ powerful verb

☐ natural collocation

☐ expression used naturally

Word count: _____ / 150

SELF-ASSESSMENT

☐ My word choices are precise.

☐ My verbs suit the actions.

☐ My collocations are natural.

☐ I avoided forced vocabulary.

☐ My expressions suit the tone.

☐ I varied sentence openings.

☐ My grammar is controlled.

☐ My paragraph is organised.

ANSWER KEY & EXPLANATIONS

Exercise 1 — Match

1–H, 2–F, 3–A, 4–C, 5–E, 6–G, 7–D, 8–B

Exercise 2 — Best Word in Context

1. **B — exhausted** — The hikers are extremely tired after prolonged effort.
2. **A — apprehensive** — The anxiety concerns an event that is about to happen.
3. **C — astonished** — The result is unexpected and surprising.
4. **B — limped** — The injury affects the player's manner of walking.
5. **C — snapped** — The words are sudden and angry.
6. **A — crept** — The thief moves quietly to avoid being heard.
7. **B — serious concern** — This is the natural formal collocation.
8. **B — breathed a sigh of relief** — The expression accurately shows relief after danger or worry.

Exercise 3 — Suggested Corrections

1. Heavy rain began just as the match started.
2. The principal made a decision after speaking to the teachers.
3. The luxury hotel caused bitter disappointment among families who could not afford it.
4. The injured man limped towards the ambulance.
5. She shouted loudly across the crowded hall. / She whispered to the person beside her.
6. I was devastated when my passport disappeared.
7. A wave of relief washed over me when I heard the good news.
8. The hall fell into utter silence before the ceremony.

Exercise 4 — Sample Upgrades

1. The exhausted boy trudged towards the gate.
2. A wave of panic washed over me when the lights went out.
3. The teacher glanced at the clock.
4. The room fell into utter silence.
5. The committee expressed serious concern about the cost of the trip.
6. I breathed a sigh of relief when the missing child was found.

Exercise 5 — Sample Responses

1. My mouth went dry as a shadow moved behind the window, and my hands began to tremble.
2. Sara's jaw tightened, and she gripped the broken trophy so firmly that her knuckles turned white.
3. I released the breath I had been holding when the doctor smiled.
4. Ahmed twisted his notes between his fingers and avoided the audience's gaze before beginning his speech.

OPEN-ENDED TASKS

Accept other answers when the vocabulary is precise, the collocation is natural, the grammar is accurate and the expression suits the context. Do not reward difficult words that distort the meaning.